In 1785, feeling that all had been done for the moment that lay in his power in the matter of the prisons, he sought a new channel into which his power for well-doing might be turned, and found it in an investigation of the source and best methods of treating the plague, whose frightful effects could be seen in every port in Europe. These investigations, together with the result of a further tour of the prisons, he embodied in a volume published in 1789 called *An Account of the Principal Lazarettos in Europe*. He then set off once more, this time on the journey that ended in his death. On his tomb at Cherson, fifteen hundred miles from his home in Bedfordshire, are these words:

JOHN HOWARD
WHOEVER THOU ART, THOU STANDEST AT
THE TOMB OF THY FRIEND
1790

Courage and industry are not always friendly virtues, neither are sanity, thoroughness, and determination, qualities of Howard's that may better appear from a reading of his work than from any narrative of them. Indeed a long acquaintance with suffering commonly makes men callous. But Howard would never have attained his hold on men's imagination had he not been gifted also with a sustained humanity. It is known, although he took care to leave little evidence of the fact, that in prison after prison he released unhappy prisoners by the payment of their debts, and that to those whom he was unable to relieve he came not merely as an inspector, but a friend. One story alone must suffice as an illustration. A Dutch prisoner of war once impressed Howard so much by his unselfish labours for his fellow prisoners that he asked whether there was any way in which he could serve him. The sailor at first affirmed his content with his lot, but finally confessed that when at home his greatest enjoyment was in a dish of tea. A week later a small sugar loaf, a pound of tea, and a tin kettle arrived at the prison.

Courage in war, industry in commerce, charity to the respectable poor, these were virtues that the eighteenth century could understand. But that these should be united to succour the miserable, the outcast, and the criminal, this was an idea so old as to be new again. Howard's fame became immense. A monument was raised to him in St. Paul's. Respectable citizens carved his name on their trees,

and wrote to the *Gentleman's Magazine* to proclaim the fact. Minor poets forsook their birthday odes and wrote verses on "The Triumph of Benevolence." And here and there a soul was stirred, a spirit kindled, so that a generation later Howard's biographer, in dedicating his book to Wilberforce, could say that it was in Howard's footsteps that Wilberforce had trodden, by Howard's motives that he was actuated, while in 1780, when Howard yet lived, Burke spoke these words of him:

> I cannot name this gentleman without remarking that his labours and writings have done much to open the eyes and hearts of all mankind. He has visited all Europe—not to survey the sumptuousness of palaces, or the stateliness of temples; not to make accurate measurements of the remains of ancient grandeur, nor to form a scale of the curiosity of modern art; not to collect medals or collate manuscripts—but to dive into the depths of dungeons and plunge into the infection of hospitals; to survey the mansions of sorrow and pain; to take the gauge and measure of misery, depression, and contempt; to remember the forgotten, to attend to the neglected, to visit the forsaken, and compare and collate the miseries of all men in all countries. His plan is original; and it is full of genius as it is of humanity.

If the sole interest of *The State of the Prisons* lay in the fact that its author re-awakened the public conscience to the recognition of the claims of inarticulate minorities, it would be an interesting historical document, but hardly one to be read by Everyman. But it has other more general interests.

In the first place, prisons themselves, apart from their association with crime and criminals (the raw material of half the world's romance) have a particular importance from the fact that in them alone in modern times is one man completely subjected to the power of another or others. A prisoner is potentially in a worse condition than the slave, because the slave is the property of someone whose interest it is to keep his property in serviceable condition, whereas the prisoner is owned by nobody, unless it be the State which is ultimately responsible for his imprisonment. Consequently the condition of its prisons and its prisoners is no bad indication of the development of any society and its degree of civilisation.

For this reason Howard's book throws a valuable light on the social history of Europe at the time when he was writing. It is illuminating to find that the smaller states, like Switzerland and Holland, were far in advance of the great powers, such as France and the Empire, in their treatment of their criminals